existing staff can also help IOs fill informational gaps left by uncooperative states.

Second, IOs can shift their priorities, reallocating resources to areas where they are less dependent on populist input. By narrowing their focus to tasks that require minimal engagement from resistant members, IOs can continue their operations with fewer disruptions. This flexibility allows IOs to pivot back to broader mandates once populist pressures subside. Such circumspection is a common institutional reaction to member resistance (Busch and Pelc 2010).

Third, IOs can diversify their partnerships, seeking support from alternative sources such as nonpopulist states, NGOs, or other international institutions. For example, co-financing agreements and data-sharing partnerships between IOs can help fill resource and information voids (Clark 2025). NGOs, with their extensive networks and local knowledge, can also provide critical inputs when state cooperation wanes; NGOs are plentiful in global development and environmental research in particular (Bush and Hadden 2019; Hadden and Bush 2020).

Several historical cases highlight the effectiveness of sidelining populists. During Donald Trump's first term, for instance, the Paris Agreement persisted despite US withdrawal, as other nations stepped up to fill the leadership void. Similarly, when Trump cut funding to the UN agency for Palestinian refugees, European and Persian Gulf states increased their contributions to mitigate the impact.[7] The WTO offers another example: When populist leaders blocked its agenda, the director-general sidelined these actors by negotiating around them and removing them from key positions.[8] States that desired continued cooperation also created the Multi-Party Interim Appeal Arbitration Arrangement (MPIA) to hear interstate disputes despite the unwillingness of the United States to confirm judges to the WTO's appellate body, and the MPIA has been effective at deterring breaches of WTO rules (Pelc 2024).

However, while sidelining offers a practical way to navigate populist resistance, it also has limitations. For one, this strategy risks angering populist leaders through exclusion, potentially prompting them to escalate their opposition. They might lobby other states to join their boycott, amplify noncompliance, or even withdraw entirely, leading to broader instability within the IO.